The pace would then pick up, and how! Between 6 and 6.30 a.m. the national flag-hoisting ceremony would take place, conducted by the Congress Seva Dal. Local and sometimes national dignitaries would be asked to act as chief guests. The rendition of the national anthem, from that first day in Kanyakumari to the last in Srinagar, never failed to get the heart pumping and the blood flowing.

Afterwards, the yatris, by then wide awake, would hit the road or be driven as groups to the starting point. And then the action would begin in dead earnest, as the Yatra began to unfurl like some gigantic coiled being slowly coming to life. Gigantic because it had massive groups of people.

First in order of the march came the team of musicians, aka the marching band! This group of some twenty individuals, all from south India, would line up in their shining whites, black boots and white spats, with a musical oeuvre that varied from a half-remembered waltz to Boney M's Rasputin, their pace going from Andante to Allegro, but not slow, never slow. Their music ever inspiring, ever cheering.

Sometimes ahead, sometimes behind would be the hand-picked Congress Seva Dal team of twenty to thirty individuals. They bore the national flag all the way through the roughly 4,000 kilometres of the Yatra. They were led by Digvijaya Singh, who, at the age of seventy-six, seemed to have the energy and resilience of someone fifty years younger.

Behind them came the D—the rectangular, rope-enclosed area in which Rahul Gandhi walked, along with whoever else accompanied him that day. It was no less than 100 feet long and 20 feet wide, escorted by up to a hundred security personnel. The D was a security necessity, but it also became the focal point because of Rahul Gandhi's presence.

This was the general order of the march. Behind, and sometimes ahead of the D, came the other participants—walkers who accompanied the Yatra for a few hours or for that particular day. These numbered in the thousands.

And what an atmosphere they made! Whether it was the very first day of the Yatra in Kanyakumari, when the walkers burst forth from their overnight camp to streets lined with cheering crowds, showering them with flowers; or the day in Rahul Gandhi's Lok Sabha constituency of Wayanad,